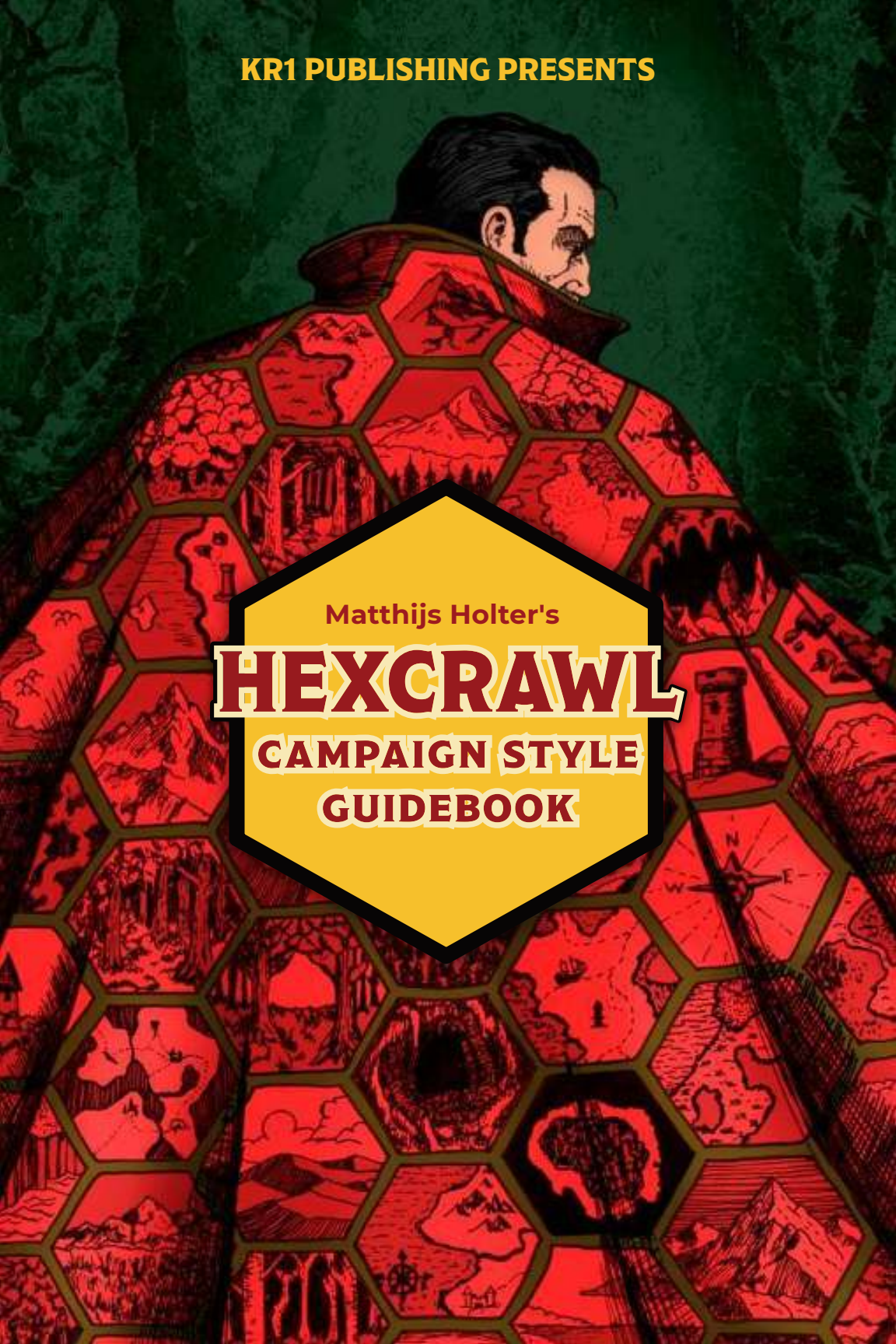


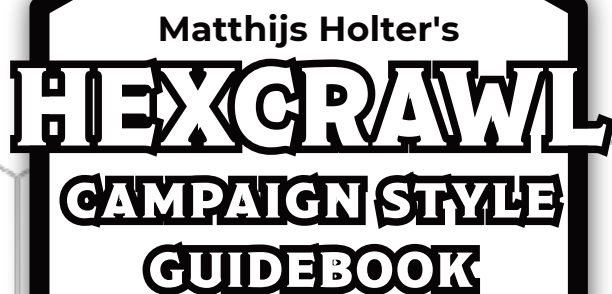
KR1 PUBLISHING PRESENTS

Matthijs Holter's

HEXCRAWL

**CAMPAIGN STYLE
GUIDEBOOK**





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HEXCRAWL

CAMPAIGN STYLE GUIDEBOOK

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FOREWORD

Hexcrawl is one of the oldest and most compelling ways to play a tabletop RPG. It's also surprisingly hard to learn from scratch. The rules aren't complex. The problem is that no one has gathered the essentials in one place. The best writing on it is scattered across decades of blog posts, forum threads, and out-of-print supplements.

When I turned a game designer's lens on hexcrawl, I found deep roots and clear principles, but no practical handbook that lays them out in one place. So I wrote one.

This is an opinionated guide. I recommend specific approaches, warn you about common failure modes, and tell you what I think works best and why, so you can adapt it to your table. Where the tradition disagrees with itself, I pick a side and explain why.

Whether you're running D&D, Shadowdark, or anything else with a map and a taste for exploration, this book will work.

System-neutral by design. You can read it in an evening and run your first hexcrawl next week.

• Matthijs



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Key terms defined by Matthijs

INTRODUCTION

What is Hexcrawl Play?

A hexcrawl is a campaign structure built on three mechanical pillars:

1. **A hex grid** that maps the wilderness
2. **Exploration turns** that give travel a procedure
3. **Keyed locations** that reward going somewhere new

This book is written for the Game Master (GM), the person who builds the map, stocks it with content, and runs the game.

What makes it distinct?

The hex grid gives every location a coordinate and every journey a measurable distance.

Keyed hexes mean the GM preps content tied to places, not to a storyline

Each day splits into four watches: *morning, afternoon, evening, night.*

During each travel watch, the group runs the exploration turn:

pick a direction, check navigation, move, roll for encounters, discover keyed content, and track resources (rations, torches, gear). That loop is the core of hexcrawl play.

The result

Players push into unknown territory, manage their supplies, and discover what you've placed on the map. What they find depends entirely on where they go.

Summary:

- *Hexcrawl = hex grid + exploration turns + keyed locations*
- *The exploration turn gives travel a repeatable procedure*
- *Content is tied to places on the map, not to a plotline*

How Hexcrawl Differs from Other Styles

Hexcrawl gets confused with other exploration-focused styles.

vs. West Marches: West Marches is a social structure: rotating players, open table, player-initiated sessions. Hexcrawl is a procedural structure: hex grid, exploration turns, resource tracking. You can run a hexcrawl with a fixed group of four. The overlap is real, but they solve different problems.

vs. Pointcrawl: A pointcrawl connects known locations along fixed paths. Locations and the connections between them are the focus, not the terrain in between. A hexcrawl fills the space between. Pointcrawl is efficient. Hexcrawl rewards wandering off the trail.

vs. Traditional Campaigns: In most campaigns, travel is handwaved: “three days later, you arrive.” In a hexcrawl, travel IS the adventure. The GM shifts from storyteller to world-runner, and the exploration turn replaces “skip to the next scene.”

Summary:

- *West Marches is a social structure built around an open table. Hexcrawl is a procedural structure built around a hex grid and exploration turns.*
- *Pointcrawl connects known points. Hexcrawl fills the space between*
- *Traditional campaigns handwave travel. Hexcrawl makes travel the main event*

A Wilderness Waiting to Be Explored

The next chapter lays out six principles that define hexcrawl play. Together, they answer the question every new hexcrawl GM asks: “Where do I even start?”

The short answer: with a small map, a handful of keyed hexes, and the willingness to let your players walk off the edge of your prep.

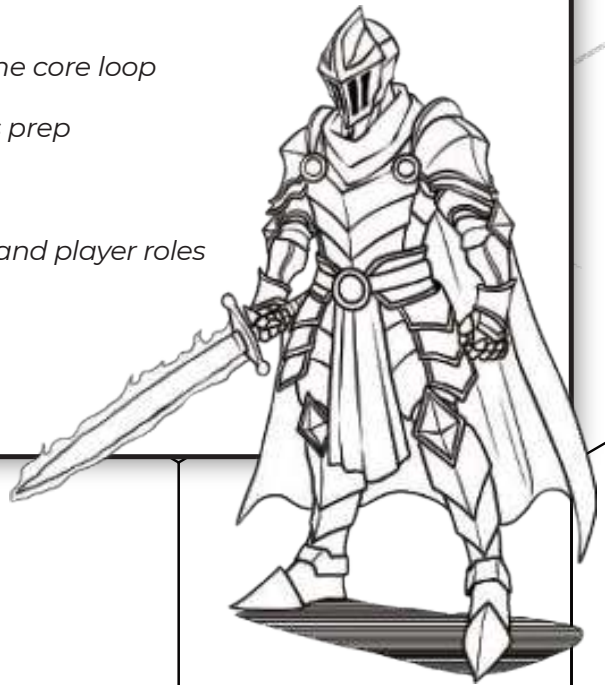
CHAPTER 1

THE KEY PRINCIPLES OF HEXCRAWL

Six principles that define hexcrawl play and underpin everything else in the book.

You'll learn:

- 1. The exploration turn as the core loop*
- 2. How the hex grid shapes prep*
- 3. Geographic danger*
- 4. Information asymmetry and player roles*
- 5. Procedural GMing*
- 6. Radiating prep*



1. The Journey is the Game

The exploration turn is the core procedure that guides the group through the landscape. Think of it like the classic combat round, but for travel: a repeatable sequence that creates rhythm.

Each day is divided into four watches (morning, afternoon, evening, night), and each watch follows a short checklist: direction, navigation, movement, encounters, keyed content, resources.

This loop is the game.

Every hex costs something: rations consumed, daylight spent, encounter risk taken. But every hex offers something too: a discovery, a shortcut, a resource, a story.

The tension between cost and reward is what makes travel matter. Do we push into the swamp before nightfall or camp on dry ground? Follow the river or cut through the hills?

Terrain reading, weather shifts, route choices, camp placement: these are hexcrawl's equivalent of *"I search for traps"* and *"I check the door."* I recommend keeping a visible procedure checklist on the table (see the reference card in chapter 3) so the exploration turn becomes second nature.

Failure mode: Watches that are just *"roll dice, I narrate some walking."* If there's no decision in a watch, compress it to one sentence and move on.

Summary:

- *The exploration turn is the core procedure: a repeatable sequence run each watch*
- *Every hex costs rations, daylight, and risk, but also offers discoveries and rewards. That tension makes choices real*
- *A visible checklist on the table makes the procedure automatic*

2. The Hex Grid Structures Everything

Why hexes and not squares? Hexes keep distances honest: every neighbor is the same distance away, with no diagonal shortcuts. Navigation is intuitive, and measurement is consistent.

In this book I use standard 6-mile hexes (~10 km). You run the exploration turn once per watch, not once per hex. On easy terrain, one watch crosses one hex. Moderate terrain (forest, hills) takes two watches. Hard terrain (swamp, mountains) takes three. More watches per hex means more resource drain and more encounter checks.

For players, distances become easy to read. “The tower is three hexes north” means something concrete: about 18 miles.

Summary:

- *Hexes beat squares because every neighbor is equidistant, with no diagonal shortcuts*
- *6-mile hexes: one watch to cross on clear terrain. “Three hexes north” means 18 miles*
- *You run the exploration turn once per watch, not once per hex*



3. Danger is a Place on the Map

In a hexcrawl, danger is geographic, not random. It's tied to specific hexes and radiates outward from safety in expanding rings. The ogre cave doesn't care that the party is level 2. It was there before them and it'll be there after.

You're not tuning difficulty to the party. You're placing threats on the map and letting players choose which ones to face.

The world warns players before it kills them. Bigger tracks mean a harder zone. Scorched trees mean something breathes fire nearby. A fleeing merchant says *"don't go east."* These are spatial warning signs. They let players make informed decisions about risk without the GM saying *"this is too hard for you."*

I recommend sketching three zones expanding from the home base: **safe** (1-2 hexes from base), **moderate** (3-5 hexes), **dangerous** (6+).

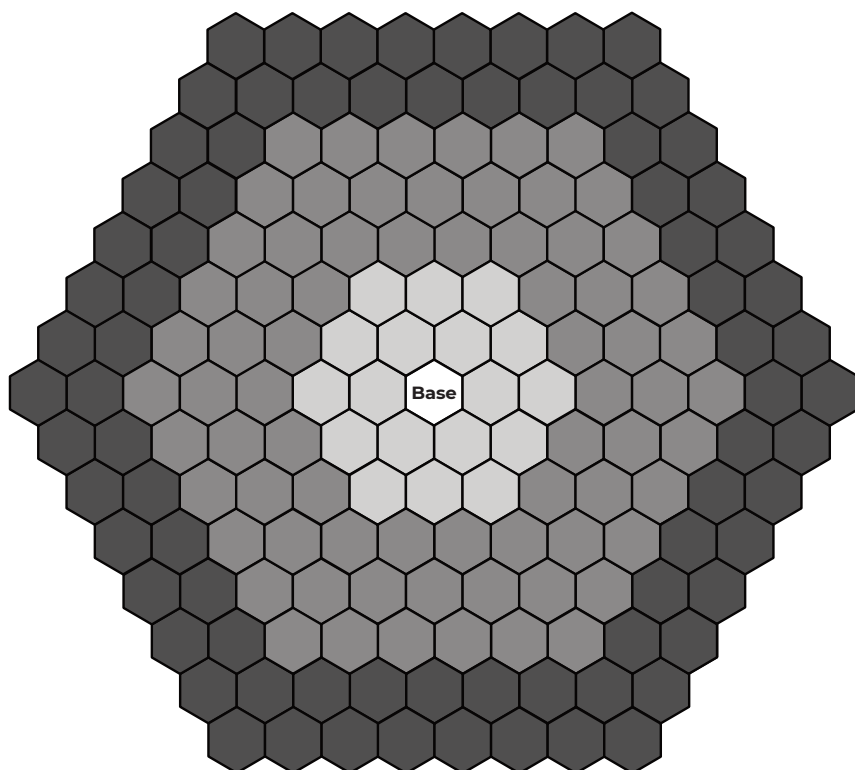
This gives you a pacing tool and gives players a visible gradient of risk.

Failure mode: A deadly encounter one hex from base, or uniform danger everywhere. Both kill the feeling that deeper = more dangerous.

Summary:

- *Danger is geographic, in expanding rings from safety, not scaled to party level*
- *Warning signs (tracks, scorch marks, fleeing NPCs) let players choose their risk*
- *Sketch three zones from the home base: safe, moderate, dangerous*

Figure 1: expanding hex rings showing three danger zones radiating from a central home base hex: White **BASE** at center, light grey **SAFE** ring (1-2 hexes from base), grey **MODERATE** ring (3-5 hexes from base), with **DANGEROUS** (6+ hexes) indicated beyond.



- ☐ **Home base:** safe, no danger
- ☐ **Safe:** 1-2 hexes from home base
- ☐ **Moderate:** 3-5 hexes from home base
- ☐ **Dangerous:** 6+ hexes - here be dragons (really)

4. Players See the World Differently Than You Do

You see a numbered hex grid with keyed entries. Players see descriptions, landmarks, and the edges of their map. That gap between what you know and what they know is central to the hexcrawl experience.

Player cartography is a core activity. When a player draws the river they just crossed onto their map, they're engaged at the most fundamental level. The map they build over weeks becomes the campaign's most treasured artifact.

Player roles make the exploration turn active for everyone:

- **Mapper:** fills in the party's map hex by hex as they explore, recording landmarks and terrain
- **Caller:** declares the party's direction and decisions each watch
- **Quartermaster:** tracks rations, torches, and gear consumption
- **Chronicler:** writes a short expedition report after each session and maintains the rumor log

I recommend assigning roles at **Session Zero** so every player has a job from the first watch. Roles can rotate between expeditions, but keeping them stable within a session avoids confusion.

Keep the map and notes in a shared location: a photo of the paper map in the group chat, or a shared digital canvas. That way the group isn't stuck if the mapper misses a session.

Failure mode: Players sitting passively, waiting for the GM to tell them where to go. That means they don't have enough information to make choices.

Summary:

- *You see the grid. Players see descriptions. That gap drives the whole experience*
- *Player roles (mapper, caller, quartermaster, chronicler) keep everyone active during travel*
- *Hand out a blank hex grid and colored pencils at Session Zero*

5. The GM is a Cartographer, Not a Storyteller

Your main job in a hexcrawl is procedural, not narrative.

You have four core activities:

Key hexes: Pick some hexes, and write a few sentences per hex (2-4 is plenty): what's here, what's interesting, what's dangerous

Build encounter tables: One per terrain type. Mix non-combat entries (tracks, weather, NPCs, strange sights) with creatures.

For example, a d6 plains table might include: (1) wagon tracks leading south, (2) dust storm cuts visibility, (3) circling vultures over a dead horse, (4) traveling tinker selling maps and rumor, (5) wild horses, skittish but tameable, (6) mounted raiders. Notice: four of those six aren't combat. See chapter 5 for a full breakdown

Track time: Watches, days, rations, seasons. Time creates consequences

Run the exploration turn: Follow the procedure, describe results honestly

A good hex key is short and evocative: *"Collapsed watchtower. Owlbear nesting in upper floor. Intact cellar with locked iron chest (old maps)."* That's enough. Expand at the table if players investigate.

I recommend writing keys per hex, each hex gets its own entry. But hexes that share a terrain type can also share an encounter table, which saves prep. One page of encounter tables per terrain type covers most of what you need.

Failure mode: Steering the party toward *"your"* content. If they go north and you prepped east, let them find what's north. The content east will keep.

Summary:

- 4 GM activities: key hexes, build encounter tables, track time, run the turn
- Hex keys should be 2-4 sentences. Expand at the table, not in prep
- One page of hex keys + one page of encounter tables per terrain = 90% of prep

6. Start Small, Expand as They Explore

Your prep is a spotlight centered on the party's position.

Keying density: In your starting region, key most hexes. Players will explore them quickly, and prepared content makes those first sessions sing. As the map grows, the ratio drops.

You don't need to key hexes the players won't reach for weeks. Focus your prep on hexes along likely routes and at terrain boundaries.

Which hexes to key: Focus on hexes along likely routes and at terrain boundaries. A river crossing, a mountain pass, the edge of the forest: these are natural decision points where interesting things should live.

How much detail: A few sentences per hex. Write what's visible, what's hidden, what's dangerous. Let play fill in the rest. If you're writing more than a paragraph per hex, you're writing too much.

Here's a keyed hex at the right level of detail:

- *"Hex 12, Crow Marsh. Knee-deep mud, rotting boardwalk half-submerged. A dead prospector clutches a hand-drawn map showing a trail east. Stirges nest in the reeds, attracted by torchlight."*

Four sentences. What you can see, what's hidden, what's dangerous. That's enough.

Start with a handful of destinations and a dozen smaller discoveries in the region around your home base. Grow outward from there as players explore. *Chapter 5* defines these categories and shows what this looks like in practice.

Failure mode: Keying 200 hexes before session 1. That's the classic burnout trap. Most of those hexes will never be visited.

Summary:

- *Key most hexes in the starting region. As the map grows, key fewer*
- *Start with a handful of destinations and smaller discoveries near the home base*
- *Trying to key everything before session 1 is the classic burnout trap.*

CHAPTER 2

STARTING YOUR HEXCRAWL CAMPAIGN

Five steps from blank grid to first session.

You'll learn:

1. *Draw a hex map*
2. *Key your starting region*
3. *Build a home base*
4. *Seed rumors*
5. *Run Session Zero*



1. Draw Your Hex Map

Start with a hex grid. For paper, search online for “hex grid PDF” and print one. For digital, any virtual tabletop with a hex overlay works. Don’t overthink the medium. A hand-drawn grid on paper is perfectly fine.

Assume the grid uses 6-mile hexes. At that scale, a journey across 3 hexes on clear terrain fills a full day of travel. A 30-hex map gives you weeks of play.

Terrain variety matters more than map size. A 30-hex map with five terrain types (forest, hills, swamp, plains, river) creates more interesting decisions than a huge map that’s all forest.

Each terrain type changes travel speed, encounter tables, and survival conditions, so place at least three types within two days’ travel of the home base.

Place natural boundaries: a mountain range that blocks easy passage, a river that must be forded or bridged, a dark forest that signals danger. These boundaries create choke points and decision points: “do we go around the mountains or risk the pass?”

Summary:

- *Start with about 30 hexes at 6 miles each. Terrain variety matters more than size*
- *Place at least three terrain types within two days of home base*
- *Natural boundaries (rivers, mountains) create interesting decision points*

2. Key Your Starting Region

Now populate your hexes. In your starting region, key most of them, with three tiers:

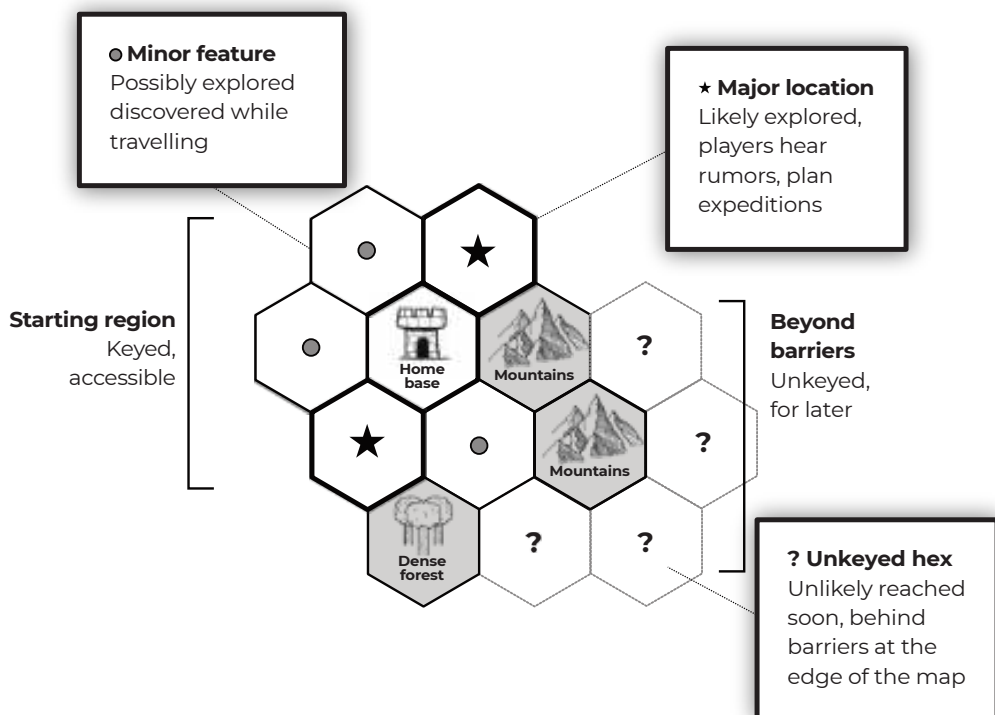


Figure 2: Small hex cluster showing home base at center, major locations nearby along clear routes, minor features along paths, and unkeyed hexes at the edges behind terrain barriers like mountains and dense forest. Labels show three tiers with their exploration likelihood.

Major location: A destination players will likely seek out. They'll hear about it through rumors and plan an expedition.

Example: "Hex 07, Iron Tower. Three-story stone tower, partially collapsed. Signs of recent habitation: warm ashes, fresh scratches on the inner walls. Locked basement door. Something is living here."

Minor feature: A discovery players may stumble on while traveling. It rewards exploration and connects to other hexes.

Example: "Hex 02, Pine Barrens. Sparse pines over sandy soil. An abandoned camp with a locked chest containing a journal. Deer trails, nothing hostile."

Unkeyed hex: Terrain the players probably won't reach soon. No written entry needed. You know the terrain type from the map, and that's enough. If players enter one, describe the landscape and roll on the encounter table.

Notice how short each entry is. Detail grows during play, not during prep. The worked example in chapter 6 shows a full 8-hex starting region built exactly this way, with encounter tables included.

See *chapter 5* for a campaign kickoff checklist that walks you through this whole setup process step by step.

Summary:

- *Major locations are destinations. Minor features reward exploration. Unkeyed hexes are blank until players go there*
- *Each tier has a different purpose, but all fit in 2-4 sentences*
- *See chapter 6 for a worked example of a full starting region*

3. Build a Home Base

Every hexcrawl starts with a safe place: a frontier town, a trading post, a fort on the edge of the wilderness. This is where every expedition begins and ends.

Your base should have:

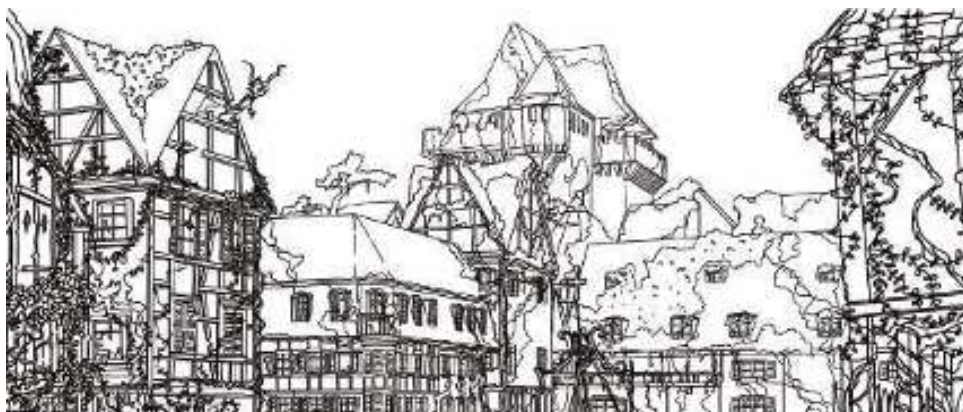
- *A name and some flavor, e.g. "Thornwall, a mud-brick town where prospectors drink and argue"*
- *A few key NPCs: shopkeeper, healer, tavern keeper, rumor source*
- *A safe haven. The base exists to launch expeditions, not to generate drama*

I recommend keeping the base deliberately uninteresting as a destination. It's a workshop, not a theme park. If the base is too compelling (political intrigue, NPC drama, side quests in town), players will stay there instead of exploring the map.

For players, the base is where they restock, compare notes, and plan the next expedition.

Summary:

- *Keep the base simple and safe, a workshop, not a destination*
- *If the base is too interesting, players won't leave*
- *The adventure is always out there, not in town*



4. Seed Rumors and Hooks

The map is blank to the players at the start. Rumors are how they fill it in. I recommend tying each rumor to a specific hex on your GM map. The players don't know the number, but you do.

Some examples:

- *"Miners found strange carvings in the canyon walls to the east."
-> Hex 06*
- *"A trader says there's a ruined tower three days north, and strange lights burn in its windows." -> Hex 07*
- *"The old hunter claims the swamp past the river shows you visions."
-> Hex 04*

Deliver rumors through the world: post them on a quest board, spread them as gossip in the marketplace, or have a wounded adventurer sell a secret at the healer's. Mix true, partially true, and misleading.

Failure mode: All rumors pointing in the same direction. If every lead says "go east," you've given players one choice disguised as several. Spread rumors across the map so the party has genuine decisions to make.

Summary:

- *Each rumor should point to a specific hex on your GM map*
- *Mix true, partially true, and misleading. The information game matters*
- *Spread rumors across the map so players have genuine choices*

5. Invite and Explain the Rules

At your Session Zero, set expectations for hexcrawl play.

These are the key differences from a typical campaign:

- *“There’s no planned route. You look at the map and decide where to go.”*
- *“The map doesn’t care about your level. Some places will kill you. The greater the risk, the greater the reward.”*
- *“Rations, torches, and gear are real constraints. You’ll track them.”*
- *“Travel isn’t downtime between adventures. The journey is the adventure.”*

A ready-to-use player handout is included in *chapter 5*.
Customize the brackets and hand it out at Session Zero.

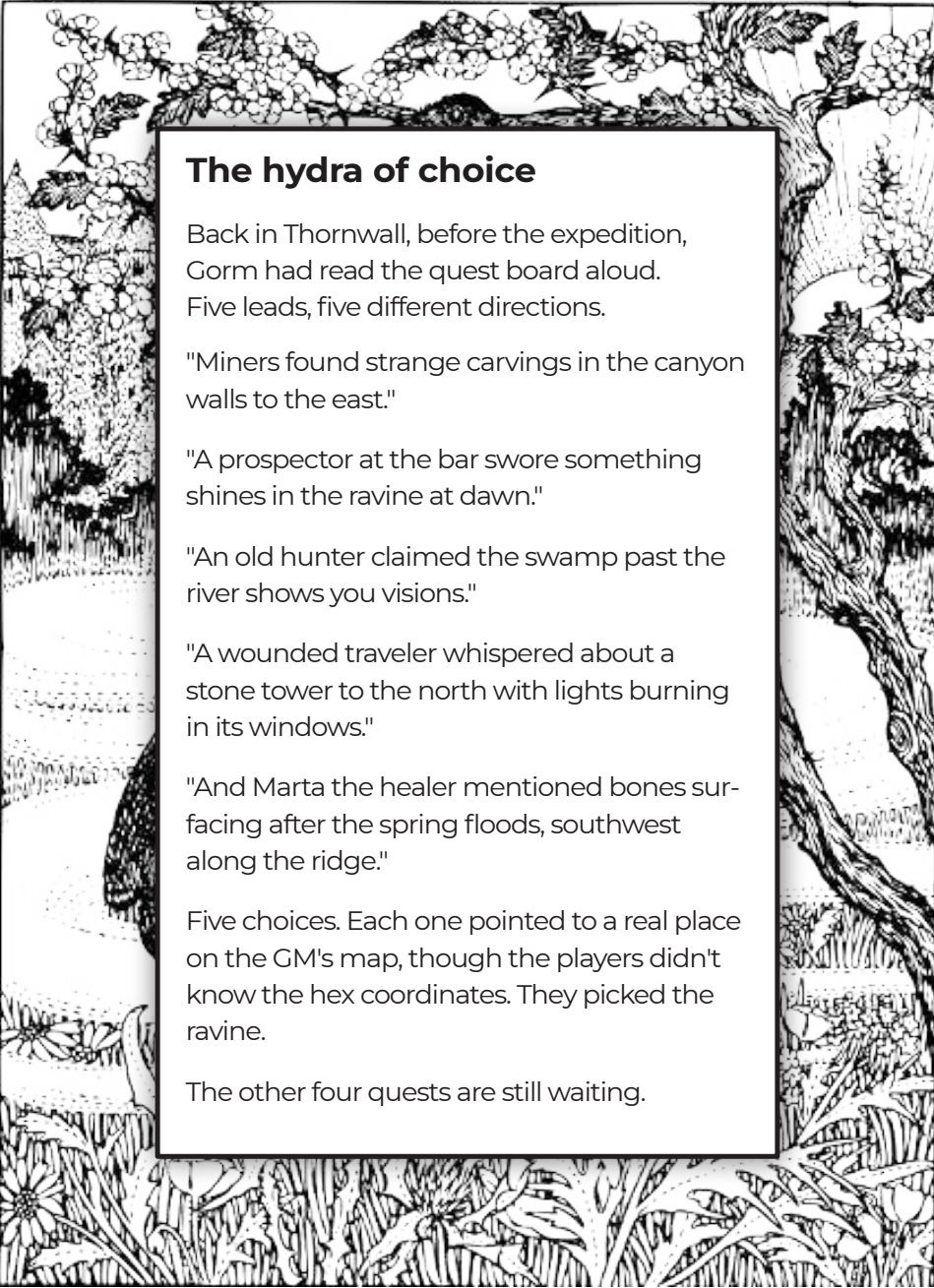
Help players build characters suited to the frontier. Anyone who can navigate, forage, scout, or survive outdoors will shine.
Combat specialists are useful but not sufficient.
The wilderness rewards practical skills more than raw power.

Then assign the four player roles from *chapter 1*:
mapper, caller, quartermaster, and chronicler.

Give the mapper a blank hex grid and colored pencils.
Roles can rotate between sessions.

Summary:

- *Explain the core loop: gear up, head out, explore, return*
- *Assign player roles (mapper, caller, quartermaster, chronicler) so nobody sits idle during travel*
- *Roles can rotate between sessions. The point is active participation*



The hydra of choice

Back in Thornwall, before the expedition, Gorm had read the quest board aloud. Five leads, five different directions.

"Miners found strange carvings in the canyon walls to the east."

"A prospector at the bar swore something shines in the ravine at dawn."

"An old hunter claimed the swamp past the river shows you visions."

"A wounded traveler whispered about a stone tower to the north with lights burning in its windows."

"And Marta the healer mentioned bones surfacing after the spring floods, southwest along the ridge."

Five choices. Each one pointed to a real place on the GM's map, though the players didn't know the hex coordinates. They picked the ravine.

The other four quests are still waiting.

CHAPTER 3

HOW TO RUN A HEXCRAWL SESSION

This is the core of the book. Here I walk you through running a hexcrawl session, step by step, from departure to return.

You'll learn:

- 1. Session prep*
- 2. Departure checklist*
- 3. The exploration turn*
- 4. Encounters*
- 5. Discovery*
- 6. Returning to base*



1. Planning the Session

Session 1 is different. You've already prepped the starting region, so you're ready. The first expedition begins at the home base: players read the rumor board, pick a direction, and head out. No advance planning needed.

Session 2 onward: I recommend having players declare their destination at least a day before the session. This gives you time to prep the right hexes without scrambling.

Ask them:

- *Where do you want to go?*
- *What's your goal for this trip?*
- *What route are you planning?*

Then prep their route: review key entries, prepare one encounter table per terrain type the party might cross (forest, hills, swamp, etc.). These are shared across all hexes of that type, saving you from writing tables per hex. Note any world changes.

Between-session planning (maps, rumors, debate) means session time is spent exploring, not deciding.

Summary:

- *Session 1: players pick a rumor and go. You've already prepped*
- *Session 2+: players declare their destination before the session. Prep their likely route.*
- *They may deviate, but you'll have the terrain and encounters ready for the area*
- *Between-session planning (maps, rumors, debate) is part of the game*

2. Prepare the Group

At the start of the session, confirm roles and run through the departure checklist:

- **Caller states the plan:** *destination, route, and goal*
- **Quartermaster confirms supplies:** *rations, torches, rope, special gear*
- **Mapper** *has their map ready and reviews what they know about the route*
- **Chronicler** *reviews notes from the last expedition and any open leads*

As GM, remind them of:

- *Known dangers in the region (warning signs from previous sessions)*
- *Rough travel distance in days*
- *Weather (example: d6, where 1 = harsh, 2-3 = poor, 4-6 = fair). Adjust the odds to fit your setting. Weather affects decisions, not only flavor*

This takes 5-10 minutes. In a hexcrawl, poor preparation can strand you in the wild with no food.

Summary:

- *Confirm player roles (caller, quartermaster, mapper, chronicler) at session start*
- *Run through departure: plan, supplies, known dangers, weather*
- *This 5-10 minute sequence sets the tone for the whole session*

3. The Exploration Turn

Each day splits into four watches: morning, afternoon, evening, and night. The first three are travel watches. The night watch is for camp and rest. Each travel watch follows the same six steps. This is the core loop of hexcrawl play.

Step A: Direction

The caller declares where the party is heading: “We follow the river northeast” or “We push straight toward the ridge.” If the party is mid-hex (because the terrain takes more than one watch to cross), the caller confirms they’re continuing or changing course.

This is a player decision, not a GM prompt. If the caller doesn’t know where to go, that’s a signal: they need better information (a vantage point, a rumor, a scout).

Step B: Navigation

On clear terrain in clear weather, no roll is needed. The party stays on course. Roll only when conditions make it possible to get lost:

- **Hard terrain** (swamp, mountains, dense fog, night travel): lost on a 1-2 (d6)
- **Moderate terrain** (forest, hills): lost on a 1 (d6)
- **Easy terrain** (plains, roads, clear weather): no roll

Use your system’s survival or wisdom check if it has one. Otherwise, a d6 works fine.

Getting lost: When the party gets lost, they drift into a random adjacent hex. Roll a d6 to pick which neighbor. The key: they don’t know they’re lost. You describe the terrain normally. They only realize something is wrong when landmarks don’t match their map, or when the journey takes longer than expected. This is where the mapper earns their keep.

Step C: Movement

Daily Travel Summary (6-mile hexes, 3 travel watches per day)

Terrain	Examples	Watch/hex	Hexes/day	Miles/day
Easy	Plains, roads, grassland	1	3	18
Moderate	Forests, hills, desert	2	1,5	9
Hard	Swamp,jungle, mountains	3	1	6

The night is for camp, rest, and guard shifts. The night procedure is covered in **Step F** below.

Three watches of travel per day is the standard pace.

- *If a hex takes more than one watch to cross, the party is inside the hex between watches.*
- *They can still be encountered, they just haven't reached the other side yet. Mark their position: "halfway through the forest hex."*
- *With three travel watches per day and easy terrain, a party can cover three hexes (18 miles).*
- *In hard terrain, they might not clear a single hex. That's the resource tension: difficult terrain eats watches, which eats rations, which shortens the expedition.*

Step D: Encounter Check

- *Roll a d6. On a 1, an encounter occurs (on a 1-2 in dangerous territory). Use your terrain encounter table to determine what they meet.*
- *The mapper updates the party's map with whatever they've seen this watch: terrain, landmarks, signs of danger. Even on a quiet watch, the mapper should note the terrain type in the hex they're crossing.*

Step E: Keyed Content

If the party enters a keyed hex, describe what they find. This is where your prep pays off. Read your hex key and bring the location alive.

If the hex is unkeyed, describe the terrain and atmosphere. Nothing specific happens unless the encounter table says otherwise.

“Dense pine forest, the canopy blocks most of the light. You hear a stream somewhere to the east.”

That’s enough.

Step F: Resources

The quartermaster tracks consumption. In a classical fantasy game, that looks like this:

- **Rations:** 1 per person per day (deduct at the end of the day, not per watch)
- **Torches:** Last 1 hour. Useful for caves and night, but not a full watch
- **Lantern + oil flask:** Lasts a full watch
- **Special gear:** Note when situational items are used up (rope left behind, potion consumed, etc.)

Adapt these to your system. The specific items change, but the principle stays: every watch spent in the wild costs something.

If rations run out, the party must forage (costs a watch), hunt (costs a watch and requires a roll), or turn back. Running out of food deep in the wilderness is exactly the kind of crisis that makes hexcrawl memorable.

Then start the next watch. Return to **Step A** and repeat. Each watch follows the same six steps until the party camps for the night or reaches their destination.

The Night Watch

Night is the fourth watch. The party camps. One character keeps guard at a time while the others sleep, rotating through the night. Assume each character pulls one shift.

- *Roll for encounters. The default is d6, encounter on a 1.*
- *Some GMs increase the odds in dangerous hexes (1-2 on a d6, or even 1-3).*

Pick what fits your table. A night encounter means the lookout spots something first: do they wake the others, observe, or try to handle it alone?

Characters woken from sleep may be groggy or unarmored. Your system probably has rules for this.

If nothing happens, the night passes. Describe it in one line:

"The night is cold and quiet. Gorm's watch passes without incident."

Then move to the next day's morning watch.

Camp placement matters:

- *High ground gives better visibility*
- *A cave offers shelter but limits escape routes.*
- *Camping near water means refilling waterskins but also means predators come to drink.*

These small decisions add texture without slowing the game.

At the Table

Here's what a morning watch sounds like in play:

Caller: *"We head northeast toward the ridge."*

GM: *"The forest is dense, roll navigation." Player rolls a 4. "You stay on course. You push deeper into the pines. That's one watch, but forest takes two watches per hex, so you're halfway through."*

GM rolls d6 for encounter: a 4, no encounter.

GM: *"Mapper, mark that you're mid-hex in forest. It's midday, what do you do for the afternoon watch?"*

A quiet watch like that takes 2-3 minutes at the table.

An interesting watch (an encounter, a discovery, a hard decision) takes 15-30 minutes.

Compress the quiet ones to keep the session moving. If nothing happens in a watch, one sentence is enough:

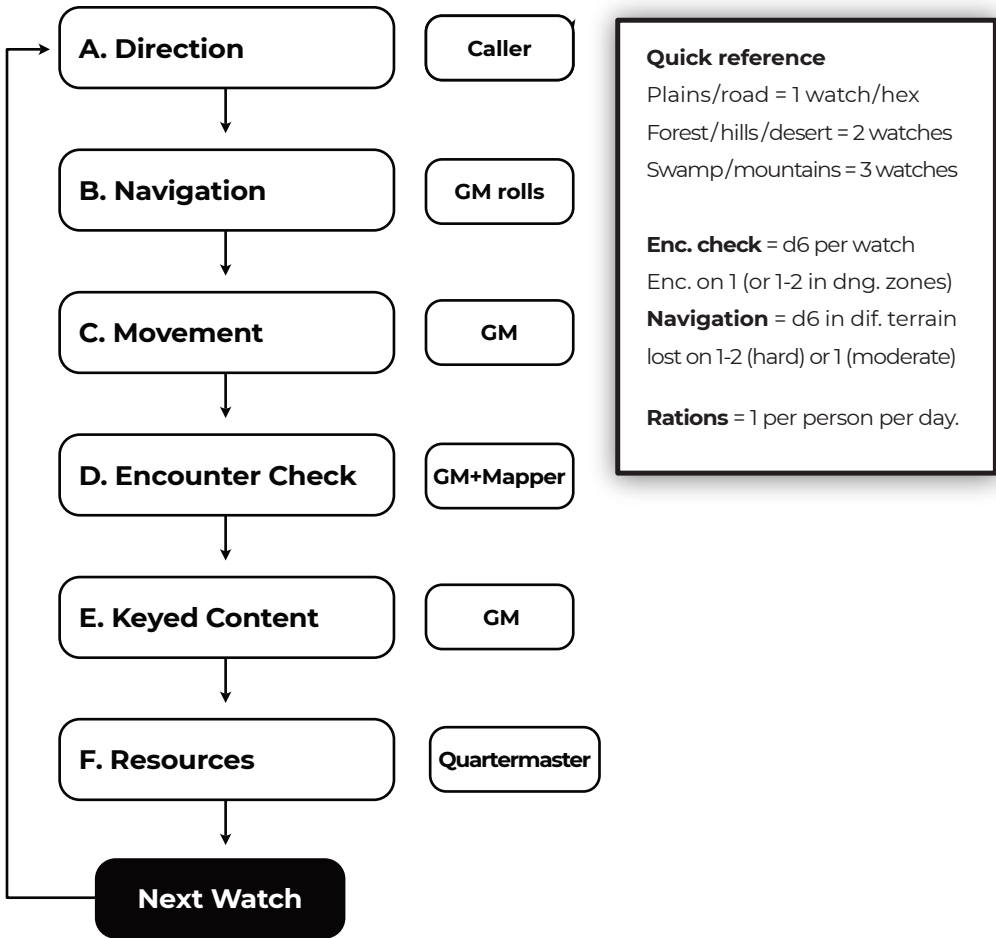
GM: *"The afternoon is uneventful. You clear the forest hex by dusk."*

Summary:

- *Six steps per watch (A-F): direction, navigation, movement, encounter, keyed content, resources*
- *Terrain speed: plains 1 watch/hex, forest/hills 2, swamp/mountains 3. Encounter check: d6 each watch, encounter on 1 (1-2 in dangerous zones)*
- *1 ration per person per day. Compress quiet watches to one sentence*

Exploration Turn: Reference Card

Run this loop once per watch (morning, afternoon, evening).
Print this card and keep it on the table.



Quiet watch: 2-3 minutes. Interesting watch: 15-30 minutes. Three watches per day.

Figure 3: 6-step vertical flowchart with loop-back arrow.

Steps: A. Direction (Caller), B. Navigation (GM rolls), C. Movement (GM), D. Encounter Check (GM + Mapper), E. Keyed Content (GM), F. Resources (Quartermaster), then NEXT WATCH loops back to step A

4. Encounters in the Wild

The encounter check is Step D of the exploration turn.

Here's how to make encounters work well.

- *You're rolling a d6 each watch and triggering an encounter on a 1 (or 1-2 in dangerous territory)*
- *I recommend building encounter tables with roughly 60% non-combat entries and 40% creatures or other potential conflicts*

Here's a sample d6 hills encounter table:

1. **Shallow cave behind a thornbush.** *Inside: a scratched map on the wall showing three nearby peaks.*
2. **Strong crosswind.** *Navigation check or drift one hex east.*
3. **Goat herder with a flock.** *Knows the region well, will share a shortcut for 5gp or a meal.*
4. **Fresh rockslide blocking the pass.** *Half a watch to climb over, or detour through the valley (add one watch).*
5. **Griffin (1) sunning on a ledge.** *Will not attack unless provoked. Its nest contains bones and a silver locket.*
6. **Orc scouts (3) on patrol.** *Will parley if shown strength. Ambush lone travelers.*



When an encounter triggers:

- **Distance:** *Are they far away or right on top of you?*
- **Reaction:** *Is the creature hostile, curious, or fleeing? Roll 2d6: low = hostile, mid = wary/neutral, high = friendly. If your system lacks one, use this scale.*
- **Player choice:** *Do they approach, avoid, or observe?*

Not every encounter is a fight. A pack of wolves might be tracking prey. A merchant caravan might offer news. A ruined wagon might hold clues to a keyed hex nearby.

Failure mode: All-combat encounter tables. If every encounter is a fight, the world seems one-dimensional, and players learn to avoid travel entirely. Variety turns hexcrawl travel into exploration instead of a gauntlet.

Summary:

- *Build encounter tables at 60% non-combat, 40% creatures or other potential conflicts*
- *Use reaction rolls and distance. Not every encounter is a fight*
- *All-combat tables teach players to avoid travel. Variety keeps them exploring*



5. Discovery and Exploration

Keyed content is Step E of the exploration turn. Here's how to bring locations alive.

The best moments in a hexcrawl are when players find something unusual and interesting. A crumbling tower on a cliff. A cave behind a waterfall. A stone circle humming with energy.

Visible discoveries draw players toward them without the GM needing to steer. From high ground, I recommend letting players see landmarks 2-3 hexes away: a column of smoke, a dark tower, a mountain peak. This gives them reasons to change course and rewards climbing hills.

Hidden discoveries reward careful exploration. A buried entrance, a concealed path, a camouflaged camp. These require players to say *"I search the area,"* and that engagement is where hexcrawl shines.

When players reach a keyed location, bring it alive:

GM: *"You crest the ridge and see it: a stone tower, three stories tall, the top floor collapsed. Crows circle the ruin. Fresh scratches on the front door frame."*

Players: *"We circle it first. Any other entrances?"*

GM: *"Around back, a rusted cellar hatch. And bootprints in the mud, heading inside."*

Some locations are a single encounter. Others fill a whole session.

Failure mode: Every discovery is a combat encounter. If finding things always means fighting, players stop wanting to find things. Mix in wonders, resources, clues, and safe discoveries.

Summary:

- *High ground should let players see landmarks 2-3 hexes away*
- *Mix visible and hidden discoveries. Both pull players forward*
- *Not all discoveries should be dangerous. Wonders and clues matter too*

6. Returning to Base

Expeditions end when the party returns to base. The outbound journey is full of unknowns.

That's where the big decisions live. The return covers familiar ground, so you have options:

- **Compress it:** *One encounter check for the whole journey back, then narrate the arrival. Good for keeping the session moving.*
- **Show consequences:** *The party passes through hexes they've changed. The bandits they scattered have regrouped. The bridge they damaged is now impassable. The return trip shows what their actions changed.*
- **Surprise them:** *Factions and NPCs don't stand still. A new camp has appeared on the road. The safe river crossing is now guarded. The world moved while they were away.*

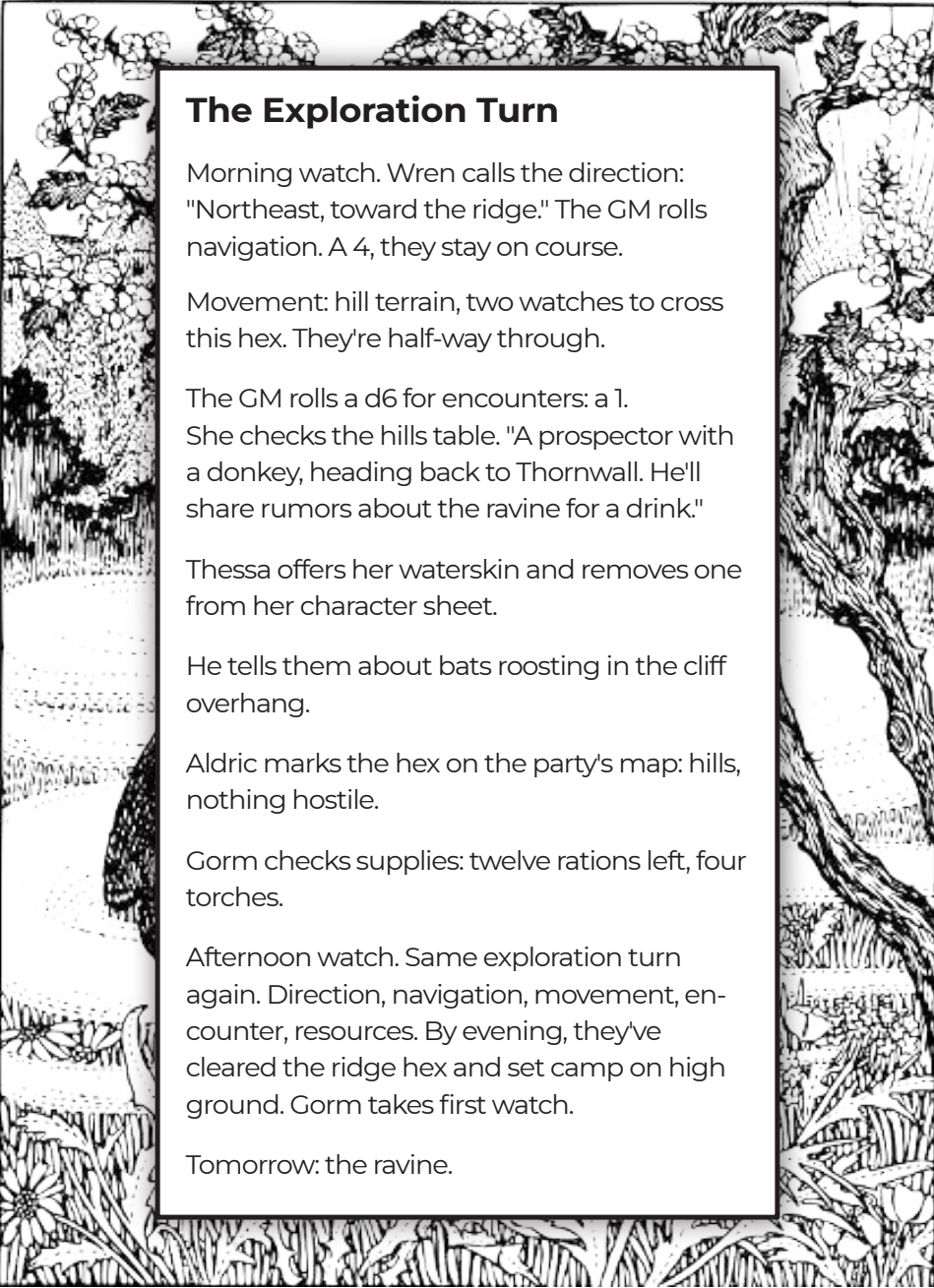
Match the approach to the moment. If the session is running long, compress. If the players made waves, show what changed.

As the session nears its end:

- *Ask the quartermaster to report how far they are from base and how many rations they have left.*
- *If they make it back: they're safe, time passes, and their discoveries become part of the world.*
- *If they don't make it back, note where they are. Next session picks up there, and resources keep ticking.*
- *Encourage the chronicler to review their notes: what did they find, what's still out there, what do they want next?*

Summary:

- *I suggest compressing the return: one encounter check, then narrate*
- *The return is when the expedition report starts forming*
- *Smart retreats and early returns are valid play*



The Exploration Turn

Morning watch. Wren calls the direction: "Northeast, toward the ridge." The GM rolls navigation. A 4, they stay on course.

Movement: hill terrain, two watches to cross this hex. They're half-way through.

The GM rolls a d6 for encounters: a 1. She checks the hills table. "A prospector with a donkey, heading back to Thornwall. He'll share rumors about the ravine for a drink."

Thessa offers her waterskin and removes one from her character sheet.

He tells them about bats roosting in the cliff overhang.

Aldric marks the hex on the party's map: hills, nothing hostile.

Gorm checks supplies: twelve rations left, four torches.

Afternoon watch. Same exploration turn again. Direction, navigation, movement, encounter, resources. By evening, they've cleared the ridge hex and set camp on high ground. Gorm takes first watch.

Tomorrow: the ravine.

CHAPTER 4

BETWEEN EXPEDITIONS

Managing downtime and world growth between sessions.

You'll learn:

- 1. Downtime activities*
- 2. Resources and gold*
- 3. Sharing knowledge*
- 4. Factions and the living world*
- 5. Time passing*



1. Downtime Activities

When characters return to base, they can take downtime actions (things that happen “off-screen” between expeditions). Frame these as player choices, not GM assignments:

“What does your character do this week?”

- **Rest and recover:** Heal injuries, cure conditions, recover from exhaustion
- **Resupply:** Buy rations, torches, rope, special gear for the next trip
- **Research:** Ask around about ruins, creatures, or a region they plan to visit
- **Hire help:** Pay for guides, porters, or guards
- **Contribute to the base:** Fund a new shop, build a stable, sponsor a scout post. Every investment should make the next expedition easier or open new routes.

For example: *“Aldric spends the week asking about the dwarven symbols from the cave. The scholar says they mark a tomb entrance, and that the dwarves trapped their tombs.”*

That’s one downtime action that gives the party actionable information for their next expedition. A good rule of thumb: each character can complete one downtime task per week. Players can stay longer, but remind them that the world outside the gates keeps moving. Factions advance, weather shifts, and opportunities expire. The adventure is out there.

Summary:

- *Frame downtime as player choices: “What does your character do this week?”*
- *Downtime actions can yield new rumors, gear, or advantages*
- *Connect downtime results to the next expedition whenever possible*

2. Resources and Gold

In a hexcrawl, gold funds the next expedition. That gives it purpose beyond treasure hoarding.

The goal isn't detailed accounting. It's real choices about how to spend limited resources. Set prices so that a single expedition is affordable but a long one hurts.

A rough scale: rations cost 1gp per person per day, a porter runs 5gp per day, a guide who knows the eastern trails costs 20gp, and a boat to cross the lake costs 50gp.

- *Rations, porters, healing, information, and base improvements should all compete for the same pool of gold.*
- *40gp of copper ore from the ravine funds three days of exploration or one porter for a week. That's a real choice, not bookkeeping.*
- *I recommend tying gold directly to the map. Every purchase should open new territory or make existing routes safer.*
- *A boat lets you cross the lake instead of hiking around it, saving two days.*
- *Cold-weather gear opens the mountain pass, and what's up there is worth the cost: rarer finds, stranger ruins, factions no one else has reached.*
- *A hired scout knows the eastern trails.*

Rations and torches are the baseline cost of movement. Gold buys the upgrades that change which hexes are reachable. Gold makes the map bigger.

Summary:

- *Use a rough pricing framework: real choices, not detailed accounting*
- *Every treasure hoard should connect to the next expedition's possibilities*
- *Gold buys capability (boats, porters, info), not power (magic items)*

3. Sharing Knowledge

The shared map is where the campaign lives. After each session, the mapper updates it with new terrain, landmarks, dangers, and discoveries.

The mapper tracks the hex grid, and the chronicler (introduced in chapter 1) keeps expedition reports and the rumor log up to date after each session.

Rotate the chronicler role if writing isn't everyone's thing. The shared map stays with the mapper. The chronicle stays with the group.

Physical map on a wall, or shared digital canvas for online play. Either way, the map is player-owned.

Summary:

- *The mapper updates the shared map after each session. It's where the campaign lives*
- *Expedition reports, rumor logs, and color-coded markers keep knowledge organized*
- *The map is player-owned, their record of the world, not yours*



4. Factions and the Living World

The wilderness shouldn't stand still while the players are in town. Factions make the hex map feel alive.

A faction is any group with a name and an agenda. You probably won't need factions until a few sessions in, when the players have made enough noise to attract attention. When you do, keep a short list. For each faction, note three things: who they are, what they want, and one or two key figures the players might meet. For example:

- **Goblins of Hex 03** (want to expand territory).
Leader: Skrag, a cunning scout.
- **Iron Road Merchants** (want safe trade routes).
Contact: Dalla, a caravan boss who pays for information.
- **The Displaced Bandits** (want revenge on the party).
Leader: Harsk, a scarred veteran the players will recognize.



Between sessions, ask yourself: “What has changed?”

Pick one or two things:

- *The goblins have moved from Hex 03 to Hex 05, and the bridge crossing is now guarded*
- *The Iron Road Merchants have established a camp at Hex 04, bringing new rumors and trade*
- *The bandits the party drove off have regrouped two hexes further east*

As factions grow important, add them to your encounter tables. If the goblins control Hex 05, they should show up on that hex's encounter rolls.

Failure mode: Factions that only exist in hexes the players haven't been to yet. If changes never touch explored territory, they're invisible.

This gives you everything you need to run factions. Once you've played a campaign or two, the Encounter Design Guidebook has more techniques for weaving factions into your encounter tables.

Summary:

- *A faction needs three things: a name, an agenda, and a key figure*
- *Between sessions, ask “what has changed?” and update 1-2 factions*
- *Add important factions to encounter tables so players meet them on the road*

5. Time Keeps Moving

I recommend a default of 1 week of in-game time between sessions. This creates natural consequences without overwhelming bookkeeping.

That means:

- *Seasons change, affecting travel speed and survival conditions*
- *Rumors grow old or are overtaken by events*
- *Enemies regroup, fortify, or move on*
- *New threats emerge, especially if left unchecked*

Start each session with a brief update:

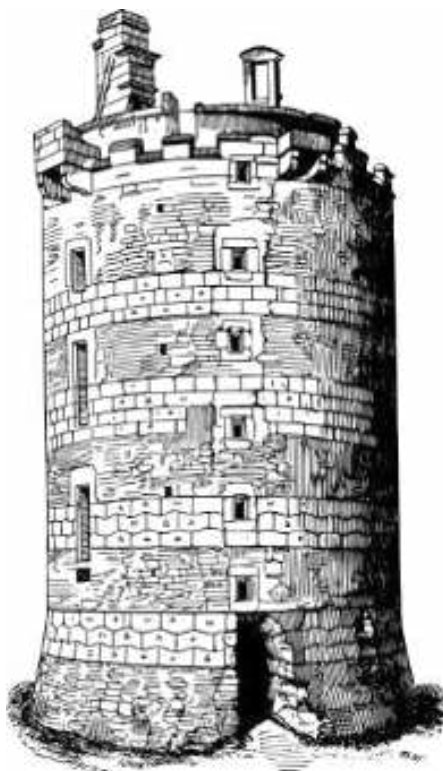
“A week has passed. The first snow has fallen on the ridge. A new merchant arrived in Thornwall.”

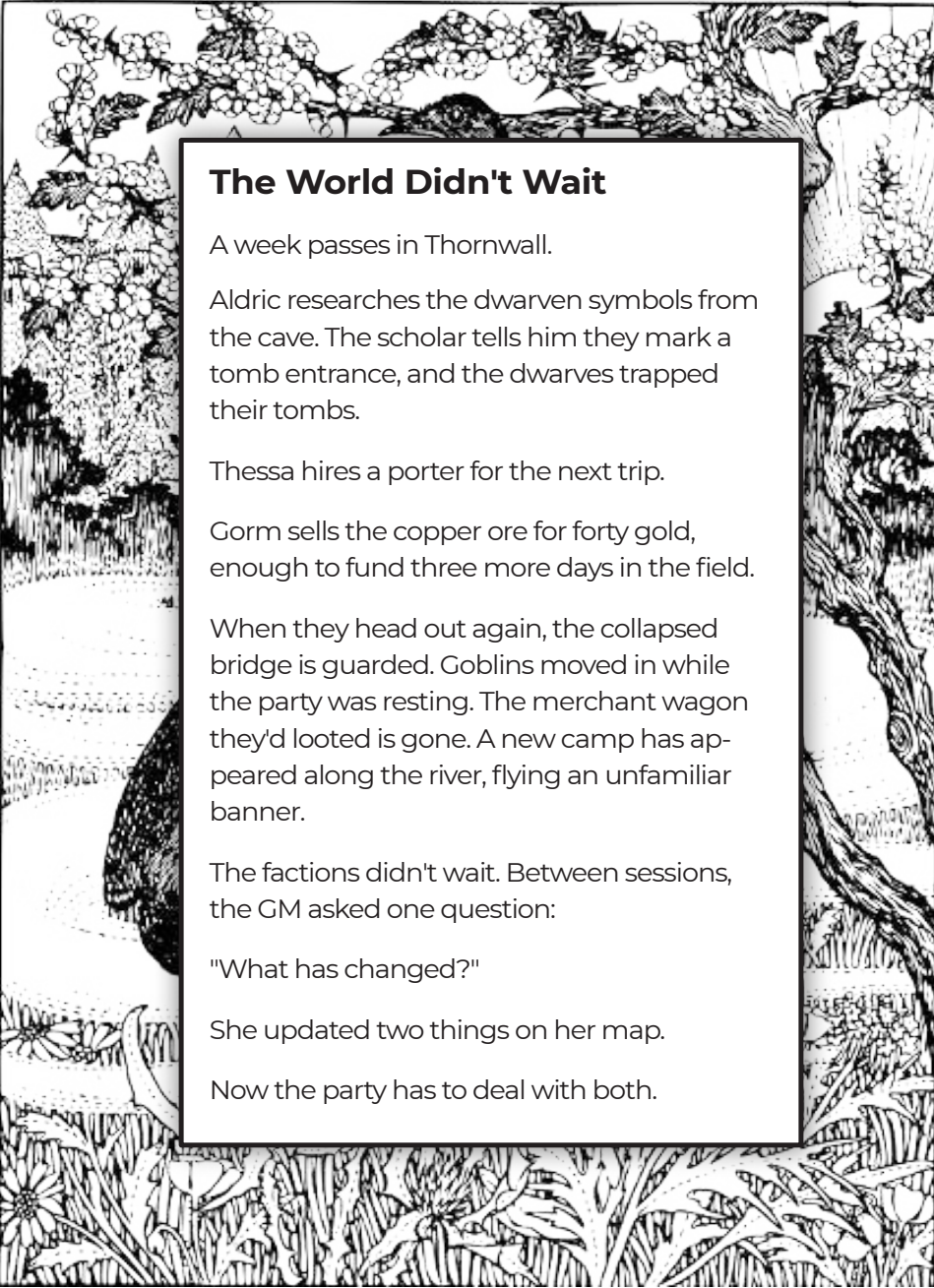
This signals that the world doesn't pause for them.

A loose week count is enough.

Summary:

- *Default to 1 week of in-game time between sessions*
- *Start each session with a brief “what’s changed” update*
- *Time passing creates urgency. Leads don’t wait forever*





The World Didn't Wait

A week passes in Thornwall.

Aldric researches the dwarven symbols from the cave. The scholar tells him they mark a tomb entrance, and the dwarves trapped their tombs.

Thessa hires a porter for the next trip.

Gorm sells the copper ore for forty gold, enough to fund three more days in the field.

When they head out again, the collapsed bridge is guarded. Goblins moved in while the party was resting. The merchant wagon they'd looted is gone. A new camp has appeared along the river, flying an unfamiliar banner.

The factions didn't wait. Between sessions, the GM asked one question:

"What has changed?"

She updated two things on her map.

Now the party has to deal with both.

CHAPTER 5

GAMEMASTER'S TOOLKIT

In this chapter I have gathered the ready-to-use tools, checklists, and tips you need for organized, efficient prep.

You'll learn:

1. *Essential tools*
2. *Campaign kickoff checklist*
3. *Session prep checklist*
4. *Building encounters*
5. *Sample player-facing document*
6. *Between-sessions checklist*
7. *Long-term campaign tips*
8. *When players arrive somewhere strange*



1. Essential Tools

You need three tools for Session Zero:

- *Hex map with terrain types filled in (hand-drawn or digital)*
- *Hex key document: numbered entries, 2-4 sentences each*
- *Encounter tables: one per terrain type, d6 is enough to start*

Once you're running, add these as needed:

- **Blank hex grid:** *for player mapping (physical or digital)*
- **Session log:** *A few bullet points after each game: where the party went, what they found, what they left unfinished. The chronicler (chapter 1) keeps the player version. You keep your own, including things the players don't know yet.*
- **Rumor tracker:** *A simple table with three columns: the rumor, where it came from, and its status. You don't need to decide whether a rumor is true when you write it. Let play settle that.*

Rumor	Source	Status
"Something shines in the eastern ravine at dawn"	Tavern keeper, session 2	Investigating
"The Iron Tower is cursed, no one returns"	Traveling merchant, session 3	Unverified
"Goblins are afraid of the standing stones"	Captured goblin, session 4	Confirmed

- **World clock:** *A numbered list of in-game weeks. After each session, note what changed in the world: factions moved, seasons shifted, threats grew. This doesn't need to be detailed. It just keeps time feeling real. For example:*

Week	What changed
1	Goblins spotted near the bridge.
2	Merchant caravan arrives at Thornwall. First frost, swamp partially freezes.
3	Party rests in Thornwall. Ranger forages, thief ask around about the tower.
4	Goblins now control bridge crossing. Bandits regroup east of the river

2. Campaign Kickoff Checklist

Map Setup

- ☐ Hex grid with terrain (about 30 hexes, 6 miles each)
- ☐ A handful of major locations keyed
- ☐ A dozen minor features keyed
- ☐ Danger zones sketched (safe / moderate / dangerous)
- ☐ Encounter table per terrain type

Home Base Setup

- ☐ Named settlement with a few NPCs
- ☐ Shop/market for supplies
- ☐ Source of rumors (tavern, notice board, NPC)
- ☐ Safe, no danger or intrigue in town

Player Setup

- ☐ Player-facing welcome document (section 5 below)
- ☐ Blank hex grid and colored pencils for the mapper
- ☐ Player roles assigned (mapper, caller, quartermaster, chronicler)
- ☐ Expedition report template
- ☐ 5+ starting rumors on the board

GM Setup

- ☐ Exploration turn procedure on the table (chapter 3)
- ☐ Session prep checklist ready (section 3 below)
- ☐ Encounter tables built (section 4 below)

Session Zero Goals

- ☐ Explain the six core principles
- ☐ Assign player roles and hand out the blank map
- ☐ Help players make characters
- ☐ Plan the first expedition!

3. Session Prep Checklist

Session prep should take 30-60 minutes. If you're spending 3+ hours, you might be over-keying, or you might just love world-building. Either way, most of that detail won't hit the table this session. Prep what's on the party's route and save the rest.

Before Prep:

- *Get the players' destination and route (before the session)*
- *Identify the hexes along their likely path*

Prepare:

- *Key unkeyed hexes on their route and prepare 2-3 encounters per terrain type*
- *Any NPCs or creatures at their destination*
- *Weather and travel conditions*
- *Review rumors and previous discoveries*
- *1-2 world changes since last session (factions, weather, events)*

That's it. Let the players fill in the rest with their choices.

Failure mode: Prepping everything the players might do. Prep what they said they'll do. If they change course mid-session, improvise or use your encounter tables

4. Building Encounters

I recommend a 60/40 split: 60% non-combat, 40% creatures or other potential conflicts.

Here's a sample d6 swamp encounter table:

- 1. Rotting boardwalk ends abruptly.** *An old trail marker points southeast, half-submerged.*
- 2. Thick fog rolls in.** *Navigation check or drift one hex off course.*
- 3. Dead birds floating in a pool.** *The water smells of sulfur. Something deeper is wrong here.*
- 4. Trapper checking snares.** *Knows which paths are passable this season, will share for 5gp.*
- 5. Swarm of stirges (6).** *Rise from the reeds when disturbed. Flee if a torch is waved.*
- 6. Lizardfolk patrol (3).** *Territorial but not hostile. Will trade information about the swamp for metal tools.*

Notice: entries 1-4 are non-combat. Entry 3 foreshadows a larger hazard. Entry 4 offers trade. Entries 5-6 use reaction rolls and aren't automatically hostile.

Notice that entry 1 points somewhere, southeast. If players follow that trail marker, you need something in the next hex. When you write clue encounters, prep what's at the other end, even if it's just a sentence.

Each terrain type should have its own table.

Failure mode: Every entry is "d6 goblins attack." Monotone tables make players dread travel instead of exploring. The tables and techniques in this section will carry you through many sessions.

If you want to go deeper, the *Encounter Design Guidebook* covers layered encounters, terrain-specific.

5. Sample Player-Facing Document

Hand this out at Session Zero. Customize the [brackets] for your game.

“Welcome to the Hexcrawl!”

You'll explore unknown territory, discover ruins, map the frontier, and manage your supplies.

How it works:

- *You decide where to go. Check the rumor board, review your map, and pick a destination.*
- *The wilderness is not balanced. Some areas are deadly. Watch for warning signs.*
- *Resources matter. Track rations, torches, and gear. Running out is dangerous.*
- *Not every fight is winnable. Retreating is smart play, not failure.*
- *The world changes between sessions based on what you do (and don't do).*

Player roles (rotate each session):

- **Mapper:** *Draw the party's map as you explore.*
- **Caller:** *Declare the party's direction each watch.*
- **Quartermaster:** *Track rations, torches, and gear.*
- **Chronicler:** *Write a short expedition report after each session and maintain the rumor log.*

To start: Make a character using [RULESET]. Check the rumor board. Pick a direction. Head out.”

6. Between-Sessions Checklist

After each session, spend a few minutes updating your notes:

- Update your hex key with anything that changed during play
- Ask “what has changed?” and update 1-2 factions (see chapter 4)
- Add or replace encounter table entries based on what the players did
- Review the chronicler’s notes for threads to develop



7. Long-Term Campaign Tips

Hexcrawl campaigns hit specific walls. Here's how to handle them:

When the near hexes are all explored: Re-key them. The abandoned camp is now occupied, the bridge has been repaired, the lair has new inhabitants. Factions move into cleared territory. If players have to travel 4+ hexes to find anything new, the early game's density has disappeared.

When players stop caring about resources: Introduce terrain that demands specialized gear (boats for coastal hexes, cold-weather kits for mountains), but make what's out there worth the cost: richer finds, stranger ruins, factions that can't be reached any other way. If gold piles up with nothing to spend it on, the resource game goes slack.

When the rumor board goes stale: Faction movement generates new rumors automatically. Returning NPCs (merchants, refugees, rival adventurers) bring fresh information from off-map.

When players want to build: Let them establish forward camps, claim hexes, and name landmarks. A second base changes the hex map's geometry, creating new frontiers.

When the starting region is fully explored: Expand the map, but make expansion earned. Require expensive or rare gear for exotic barriers, discovered entrances for underground networks. Treat the new region like you did at the start: a handful of major locations, seed rumors, let them explore.

You can expand your map for a long time with the techniques in this book. When you're ready to build richer, more interconnected regions, *The Worldbuilding Guidebook* is your next step.

8. When Players Arrive Somewhere Strange

The exploration turn gets the party to a new place. Now what? A crumbling tower, a fungal grove, a camp of lizardfolk traders. The hex key says what's here. Your job is to make the players want to interact with it.

I recommend leading with a sensory detail, not a threat.

"The air smells like wet copper and something is singing underground" does more work than "you see a cave entrance."

The first invites questions. The second invites caution. Start with something that makes players curious, not defensive.

Give every creature or NPC a visible motivation.

The ogre is dragging a dead elk toward its lair. The hermit is repairing a collapsed wall and cursing. The fungal guardians pulse brighter when you step closer to the spore pool.

Motivation is what turns a stat block into a scene. Players can't roleplay with *"hostile creature blocks your path."* They can roleplay with *"it's protecting something."*

Offer three ways in: When the party arrives at a location with inhabitants, frame three approaches:

- **Talk:** *Who here would speak to outsiders, and what do they want?*
- **Trade:** *What do they have that the party needs, and vice versa?*
- **Observe:** *What can the party learn by watching before engaging?*

Not every location supports all three. A territorial beast has no one to talk to, but you can still observe it and figure out what it's guarding. A ghost might talk but can't trade. The point is: combat is one option among several, and the GM should signal the others.

Use the reaction roll to surprise yourself: You keyed this camp as *“hostile bandits.”*

You roll reaction: 9, friendly. Now they’re friendly bandits. Why? Maybe they’re desperate, or maybe they recognize the party’s gear.

The reaction roll forces you out of your prep and into improvisation, and that’s where the best hexcrawl moments live. The scenes I remember most vividly are the ones where the dice contradicted my prep and I had to figure out why on the spot.

Connect the encounter to the map:

The lizardfolk traders know a safe route through the swamp. The hermit has a crude map of the ravine. The ogre’s lair contains a journal from a previous expedition.

Every encounter in a place should point somewhere else on the hex map. That’s how exploration builds momentum. Each discovery seeds the next expedition.

Failure mode: Locations that are puzzles with one solution, or creatures that exist only to be fought. If players can’t interact with a discovery except through combat, you’ve designed a dungeon room, not a hex.

Summary:

- *Lead with sensory details and visible motivations, not threats*
- *Offer multiple approaches: talk, trade, observe. Combat is one option, not the default*
- *Connect every encounter to the hex map so discoveries build momentum*

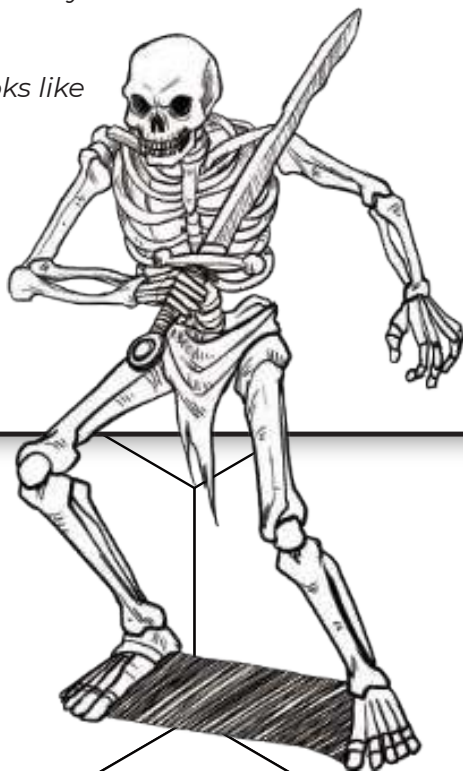
CHAPTER 6

THE THORNWALL FRONTIER AND FINAL ADVICE

Here I present a worked example of a complete starting region, an expedition report template, and some closing thoughts.

You'll learn:

- 1. A complete worked example with 7 keyed hexes and encounter tables*
- 2. What an expedition report looks like*
- 3. Final thoughts*



1. Worked Example: The Thornwall Frontier

Here are 7 keyed hexes and 1 unkeyed hex showing what a starting region actually looks like. This is enough to run 2-3 sessions.

Hex 01, Thornwall (home base). Mud-brick town on a bluff. Market square, the Antler & Axe tavern, Marta the healer. Prospectors drink and argue about what's in the hills. Rumor board by the gate.

Hex 02, Pine Barrens (minor feature). Sparse pines over sandy soil. An abandoned camp with a locked chest containing a journal. Entries describe "something shining" in Hex 06. Deer trails, nothing hostile.

Hex 03, Winding River (minor feature). Collapsed stone bridge, waist-deep ford. A submerged merchant wagon holds 30gp in trade goods. Giant crayfish (2) nest under the bridge rubble, territorial, not aggressive unless disturbed.

Hex 04, Fog Hollow (minor feature). Standing stones in ankle-deep water. Touching the central stone triggers a vision: a dark tower against red sky (Hex 07). Leeches drain 1 ration equivalent per watch spent here. Eerie, no combat.

Hex 05, Rocky Ridge (minor feature). High ground with long views. From the summit, players can see smoke from Thornwall, the river, and the dark tree line to the east. Good camp spot. Sheltered from weather.

Hex 06, Bone Pit (major location). Ancient fossils exposed in the cliff face. Giant bats roost in an overhang. Copper ore vein (valuable if mined). A narrow tunnel leads deeper, unkeyed, left for the GM to develop later.

Hex 07, Iron Tower (major location). A session-sized adventure site. Three-story stone tower, partially collapsed. Signs of recent habitation (warm ashes, fresh scratches). Locked basement door. Whatever is inside is left for you to decide.

Hex 08, Dark Pine Ridge (unkeyed). Dense forest, no trail. Roll on the forest encounter table.

Notice the variety: safe base, minor discoveries, clues pointing forward, a hazard, scenic high ground, a full adventure site, and blank forest that's just terrain until players make it more.

Thornwall Region Encounter Tables

Forest (Pine Barrens, Dark Pine Ridge): d6

1. **Old campfire, still warm.** Bootprints heading northeast toward the ridge.
2. **Deer herd crossing the trail.** Quiet, undisturbed, a sign this area is safe.
3. **Fallen tree blocks the path.** Beneath it, a leather satchel with 10gp and a hand-drawn map fragment showing a river crossing.
4. **Wandering herbalist gathering mushrooms.** Knows the local terrain. Will trade information for rations.
5. **Pack of wolves (4).** Tracking wounded elk. Hostile only if cornered or starving.
6. **Bandit scouts (3).** Will parley if outnumbered. Ambush if they have advantage.

Hills & Ridgeline (Rocky Ridge, Bone Pit): d6

- **Wind-scoured cairn on a hilltop.** Inside: a tarnished compass that still points north.
- **Rockslide blocks the trail.** Half a watch to climb over, or detour through the valley.
- **Prospector with a donkey, heading back to Thornwall.** Will share rumors about the ravine for a drink.
- **Giant eagle circling above.** Nesting on a cliff ledge, hostile only near the nest. From this vantage: clear views two hexes in every direction.
- **Wild boar (2) rooting in a thicket.** Aggressive if startled, otherwise ignore the party.
- **Strange carved stones arranged in a circle.** Touching one gives a brief flash of warmth, or is it a warning?

The Thornwall Frontier

Here's how the 7 keyed hexes from the previous page fit together on the map:

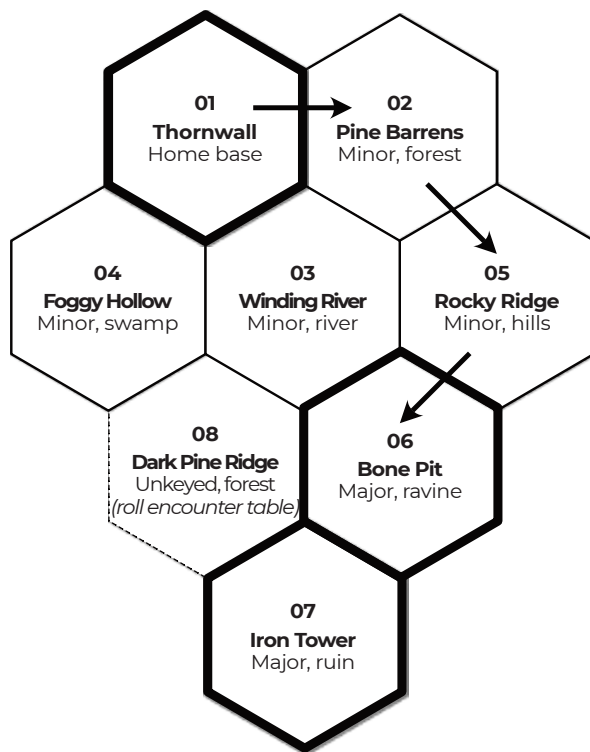


Figure 4: 7-hex region map. Row 0 (top): Hex 01 Thornwall (home base, tan), Hex 02 Pine Barrens (forest, green), Hex 05 Rocky Ridge (hills). Row 1 (offset): Hex 04 Fog Hollow (swamp), Hex 03 Winding River (river crossing), Hex 06 Bone Pit (ravine). Row 2 (bottom center): Hex 07 Iron Tower (ruin, grey). Each hex is 6 miles across.

The expedition route: 01 -> 02 -> 05 -> 06, northeast toward the Bone Pit. Fog Hollow (04) and Iron Tower (07) sit south, connected by the vision clue in the standing stones. Rocky Ridge (05) offers a vantage over the region.

2. Example Expedition Report

This example uses the Thornwall Frontier worked example above.

Expedition Report: “The Bone Pit”

Party: Wren, Aldric, Thessa, Gorm

Route: 01 -> 02 -> 05 -> 06

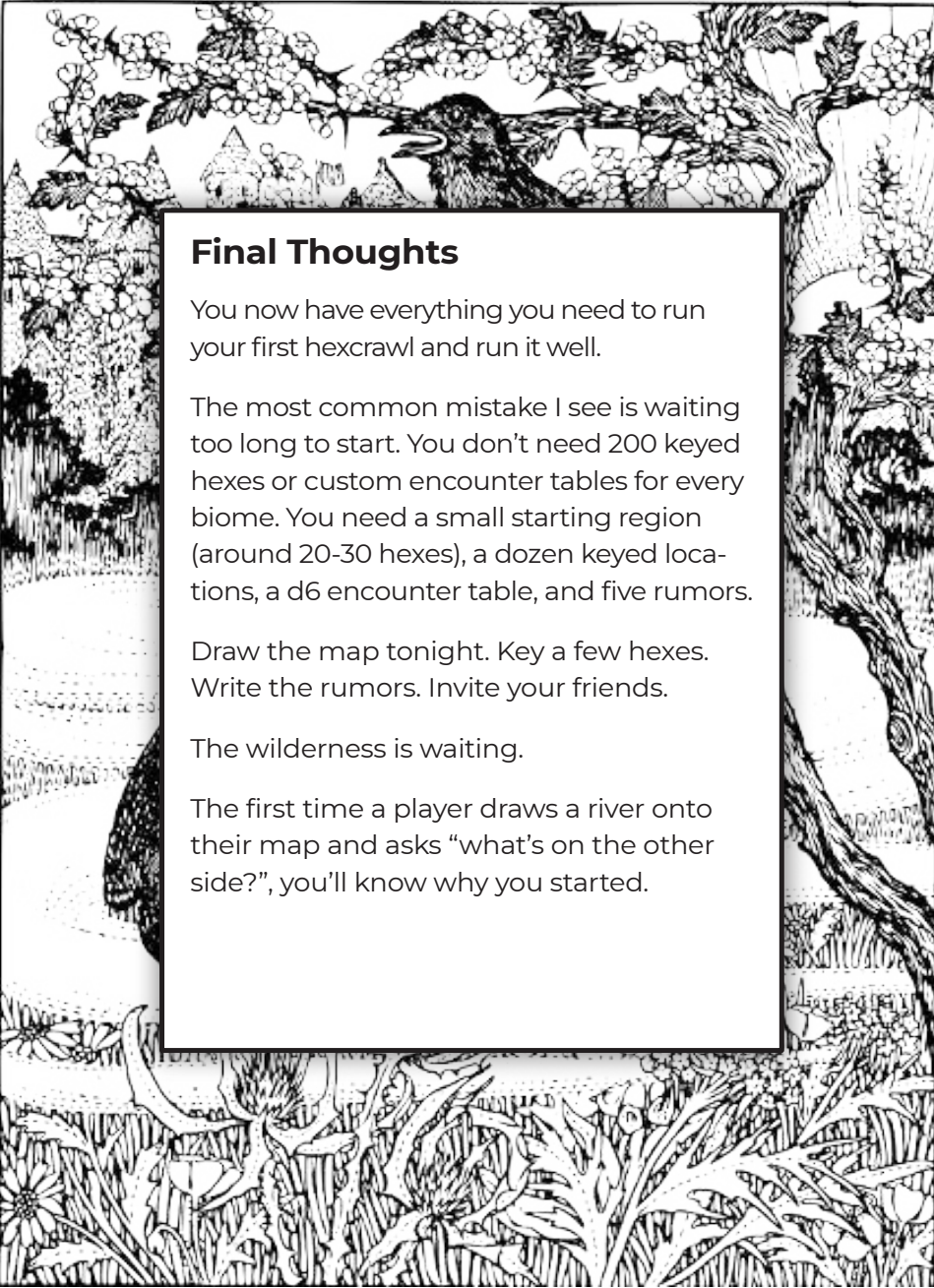
Findings:

- **Hex 02:** *journal describing “something shining in the ravine east of the ridge.”*
- **Hex 05:** *good camp spot, views in all directions.*
- **Hex 06:** *fossils, copper ore vein, giant bats (avoided), narrow tunnel unexplored.*

Treasure: 40 GP copper ore, journal

Dangers: Bats in 06

Next time: Mining tools. Use the ridge as forward camp. Translate the journal. Explore the tunnel and *Iron Tower (07)*.



Final Thoughts

You now have everything you need to run your first hexcrawl and run it well.

The most common mistake I see is waiting too long to start. You don't need 200 keyed hexes or custom encounter tables for every biome. You need a small starting region (around 20-30 hexes), a dozen keyed locations, a d6 encounter table, and five rumors.

Draw the map tonight. Key a few hexes. Write the rumors. Invite your friends.

The wilderness is waiting.

The first time a player draws a river onto their map and asks "what's on the other side?", you'll know why you started.

Glossary

Caller. The player who declares the party's direction and decisions each watch. One of four hexcrawl player roles.

Chronicler. The player who writes a short expedition report after each session and maintains the rumor log. One of four hexcrawl player roles.

Danger Zone. One of three concentric rings expanding from the home base: safe (1-2 hexes from base), moderate (3-5 hexes), dangerous (6+ hexes). A pacing tool that gives players a visible gradient of risk.

Encounter Roll. A d6 rolled each watch. On a 1 (or higher in dangerous territory), roll on the terrain's encounter table.

Exploration Turn. The core hexcrawl procedure, run once per watch: direction, navigation, movement, encounter check, keyed content, resources (Steps A-F). To hexcrawl what the classic combat round is to a dungeon crawl.

Faction. Any group with a name and an agenda that moves through the hex map between sessions. See chapter 4.

Hex Key. A numbered entry describing what's in a specific hex: what's visible, what's hidden, what's dangerous. Typically 2-4 sentences.

Keyed Hex. A hex with prepared content (a location, feature, or encounter). In the starting region, most hexes should be keyed. The ratio drops as the map grows.

Major Location. A keyed hex that players will likely seek out. A destination they'll hear about through rumors and plan an expedition to reach.

Mapper. The player who draws the party's map, records landmarks and terrain. The map they build over weeks becomes the campaign's most treasured artifact.

Minor Feature. A keyed hex that players may stumble on while traveling. Rewards exploration and connects to other hexes.

Navigation Check. A d6 roll to determine if the party gets lost. Lost on 1-2 in hard terrain (swamp, mountains), lost on 1 in moderate terrain (forest, hills). No roll needed on easy terrain.

OSR (Old-School Renaissance). RPGs revisiting early D&D principles (1974-1983), emphasizing player skill, table rulings, and emergent play. Examples: Old-School Essentials, Cairn, Knave.

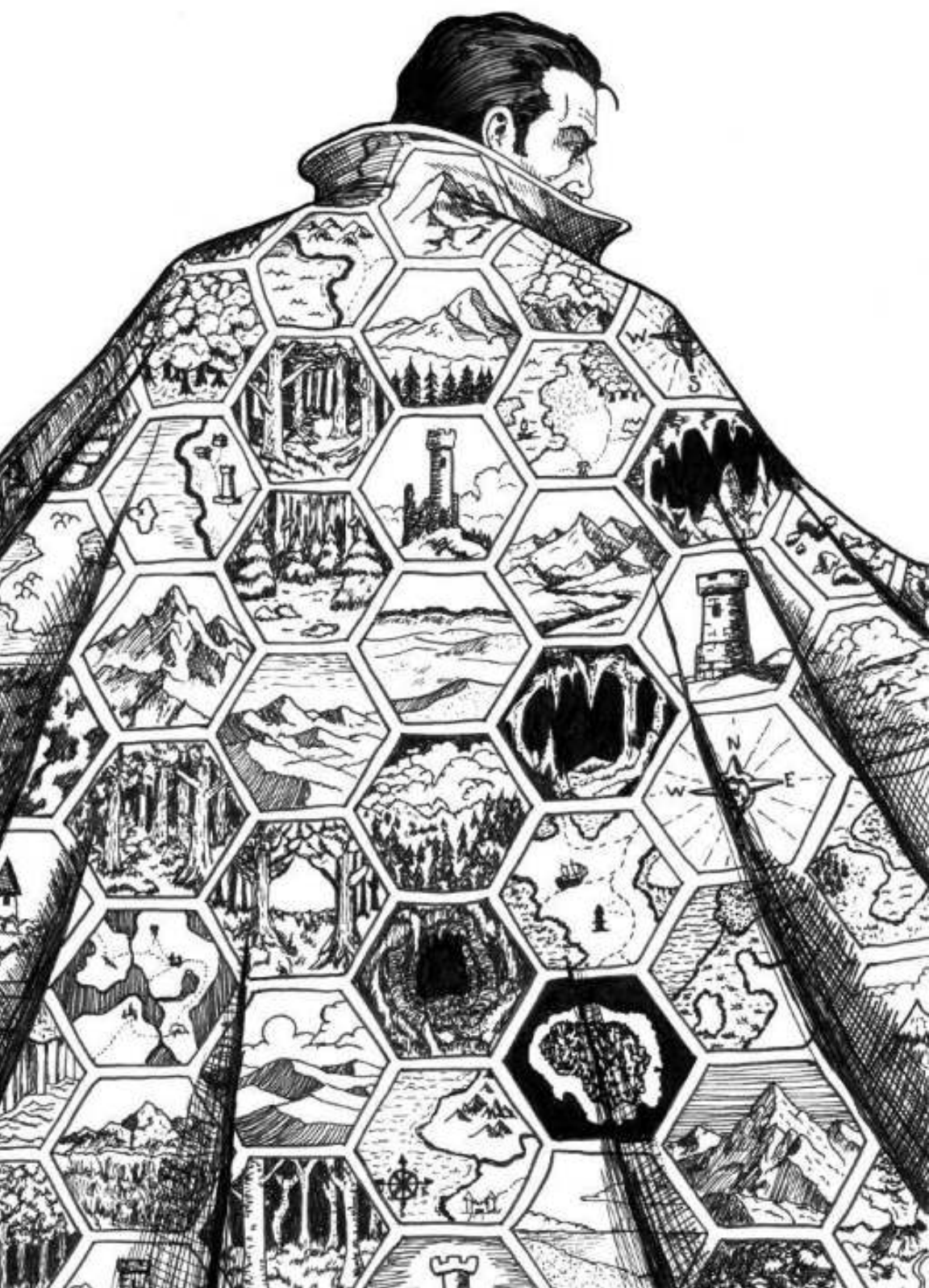
Quartermaster. The player who tracks rations, torches, and gear consumption. Resources create real decisions. The quartermaster makes them visible.

Reaction Roll. A 2d6 roll for initial NPC attitude: 2-5 = hostile, 6-8 = neutral, 9-12 = friendly. From B/X D&D (Moldvay Basic, 1981). If your system lacks one, use this scale.

Terrain (Easy / Moderate / Hard). The three terrain categories that determine travel speed. Easy (plains, roads): 1 watch per hex. Moderate (forest, hills): 2 watches. Hard (swamp, mountains): 3 watches.

Unkeyed Hex. A hex with no written entry. The GM knows the terrain type from the map and improvises if players enter one.

Watch. A 6-hour block of time. Four watches per day: morning, afternoon, evening, night. The first three are travel watches. The night watch is for camp and rest.





PRESENTS

THE HEXCRAWL SERIES

This book gave you the foundation: the exploration turn, the hex map, the session loop. You can run a great hexcrawl with nothing else. But if you want to go deeper, the rest of the series is built to snap onto what you already know.

The Encounter Design Guidebook is your next step if your encounter tables feel thin. It covers the four encounter categories (creatures, signs, hazards and discoveries), terrain-specific tables, faction presence in your rolls, slow threats that build across watches, and pacing techniques that make travel feel like a journey instead of a series of interruptions. If you've run a few sessions and want your random encounters to carry more weight, start here.

The Worldbuilding Guidebook is for when your map needs more depth. It walks you through building terrain that shapes play, keying hexes at different densities, designing factions with territory and agendas, and layering history into your landscape so every ruin tells a story. If you're expanding beyond your starting region or building a second campaign from scratch, this is where the craft lives

Each book shares the same voice, the same format, and the same assumption: you're a busy GM who wants practical tools, not theory. Pick the one that solves the problem you have right now.